

John Abbott Student Marketplace Brainstorming/Research

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User prompt: Hi, heres a recap. We are making a student marketplace for students at john abbott. It will have a simple chat system along with a page to search and browse items students are selling, and a place to then request items they desire or sell items they no longer need. Can you help us define and discover user needs, evaluate the competitive landscape, and select a viable application concept.

Response: Here is a comprehensive breakdown for defining user needs, analyzing the competitive landscape, and establishing a core product concept tailored specifically to the **John Abbott College (JAC)** student community.

1. Defining & Discovering User Needs

Targeting a specific campus like John Abbott creates unique user requirements that general platforms ignore.

Key User Personas

- **The Budget Buyer (Buyer):** Needs low-cost course materials (textbooks, lab coats, calculators), dorm/apartment essentials, or bus passes without paying full campus bookstore prices.
- **The Campus Seller (Seller):** Wants to quickly offload clutter at the end of a semester, recover textbook costs, or sell handmade items, avoiding high shipping hassle.
- **The Seeker (Requester):** Needs a niche item (e.g., a specific edition of a Humanities book, a Nursing uniform size) that isn't actively listed for sale.

Primary User Pain Points

1. **Safety & Trust:** Meeting strangers off Facebook Marketplace or Kijiji poses safety concerns; students prefer dealing strictly with verified peers.
2. **Logistical Friction:** Arranging off-campus meetups or paying for shipping kills the convenience of local trading.
3. **Information Fragmentation:** Buying/selling happens across unorganized Facebook groups, WhatsApp chats, and paper flyers pinned in the Herzberg building.
4. **Mismatched Academic Goods:** General marketplaces don't group items by JAC course codes (e.g., *NYA Physics* or *AEC programs*).

Discovery & Validation Research Plan

To validate these needs before building:

1. **Short Campus Survey (Google Forms):** Distribute across JAC student group chats/Reddit (r/JohnAbbott) asking:
 - "Where do you currently buy/sell used course materials?"
 - "What prevents you from buying from other students today?"
 - "How often do you need an item you can't find online?"
2. **In-Person Guerrilla Interviews:** Conduct 5–10 minute interviews near high-traffic JAC spots (e.g., the Herzberg cafeteria, Casgrain building, or Stewart Hall library).

2. Competitive Landscape Evaluation

To succeed, your marketplace must offer clear advantages over existing tools available to JAC students.

Platform / Channel	Strengths	Weaknesses	Your Advantage
Facebook Marketplace / Buy & Sell Groups	Large existing user base, active JAC textbook groups.	High proportion of scams, non-students, messy comments, hard to filter by course codes.	Exclusive Access: Gated strictly to @johnabbottcollege.net emails, eliminating outside scams.
Omnivox Secondhand Books List	Built into existing JAC student portal.	Clunky legacy UI, limited to textbooks, no real-time messaging (forces email/MIO).	Modern chat system, support for non-book items, "Want/Request" board.
Kijiji / eBay / Vinted	Wide selection, established payment flows.	Inconvenient meetups, shipping delays/costs, low local density.	Zero Shipping: Built specifically for instant, zero-cost on-campus handoffs (e.g., Jacobs Hall, Cafeteria).

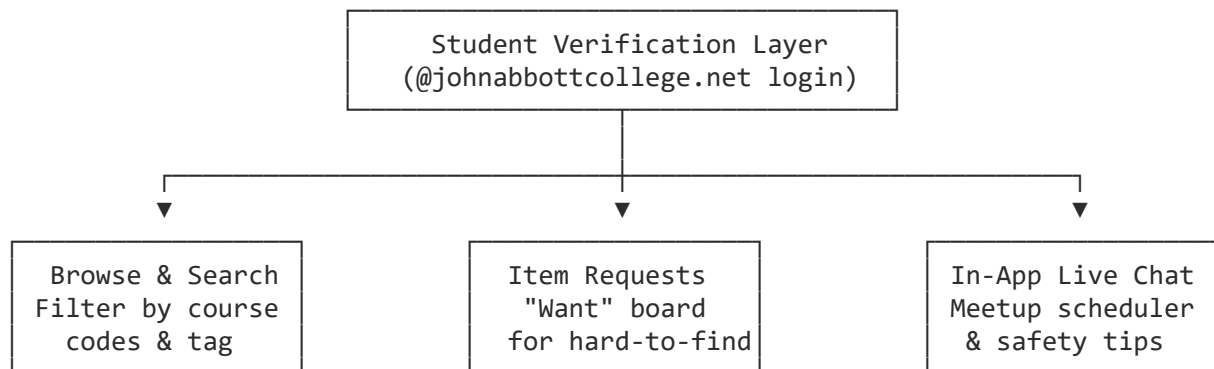
3. Recommended Application Concept: "JAC-Exchange"

To maintain development velocity while delivering maximum value, adopt a **Verified Hyper-Local Student Marketplace** model.

Core Value Proposition

"The safe, instant campus marketplace for John Abbott students to buy, sell, and request course materials and essentials."

Key Functional Requirements



1. Authentication & Security

- **Authentication:** Require account creation/login using John Abbott student email domains (@johnabbottcollege.net) to ensure a closed-trust community.

2. Search & Discovery

- **Course-Code Tagging:** Allow sellers to tag items with official JAC course codes (e.g., 201-NYA-05, 603-101-MQ) so buyers find exact textbook editions instantly.

- **Filter Categories:** Textbooks & Course Material, Electronics, Dorm/Apartment, Clothing/Sports Gear, Free Stuff.

3. "Wanted / Request" Feed

- A dedicated tab where students post what they need (e.g., "Looking for Lab Coat Size M + Safety Goggles").
- Sellers can directly reply to a request with a single tap to create an instant listing or open a chat.

4. Simplified In-App Chat

- **Real-time 1-on-1 messaging:** Keeps personal phone numbers private.
- **Smart Meetup Prompts:** Offer preset campus safe-zones for handoffs (e.g., "Meet at Herzberg Cafeteria" or "Stewart Hall Entrance").

4. Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Scope

Focus on a tight MVP to launch quickly before a new semester starts (when textbook demand peaks).

In-Scope for MVP

- [] Student email sign-up/login verification (@johnabbottcollege.net).
- [] Create listing (Photos, Title, Price, Category, Course Code Tag, Description).
- [] Request board ("I want to buy X").
- [] Simple text chat between buyer and seller.
- [] Item status toggle (Available, Pending, Sold).

Out-of-Scope (Save for Post-Launch)

- ✗ Integrated payment gateway (Stripe) — stick to cash/e-Transfer at launch to avoid financial compliance overhead.
- ✗ Complex user review systems (a simple "Member since [Date]" badge is sufficient for launch).
- ✗ Push notification infrastructure (start with simple email notifications for new chat messages).

User prompt: Through our brainstorming we think there isnt much competition as facebook marketplace is too widespread and non-specific to what our users would use the app for, so we think that because it is tailored to specific needs, one of its main benefits is that it gives all these students a single platform to buy and sell. Another "competitor" is a school provided place to sell and buy books, but it is so outdated and annoying to use its not that popular, so our app will be a solution to that as well. What do you think about that reasoning, did we miss anything or is there more to think about? Additionally, to the trust problem, we are thinking of having students sign up using their jac emails, which adds a layer of protection where random people would not be able to access the app. What additional ways could be protect our users? We also thought of just warning messages for example reminding the user to be careful, and only transfer money during the arranged time decided between the parties to transfer the item being sold. How does that sound?

Response: 1. Critiquing Your Competitive Analysis

Your core hypothesis—that general platforms are too broad and Omnivox's secondhand book module is too clunky—is **fundamentally sound**. However, there are critical nuances and hidden dynamics to consider before building:

Where Your Logic Holds Up

- **High Trust & Relevance:** Facebook Marketplace lacks hyper-local filtering. Searching for a specific course textbook on FB Marketplace brings up listings across all of Greater Montreal, requiring annoying travel for a \$20 book.
- **Omnivox's UX Flaws:** Omnivox's built-in "Find books for sale / Sell your used books" feature is dated, lacks image support, and relies on MIO (Messaging in Omnivox) or raw emails. It fails to create a smooth, modern conversational experience.

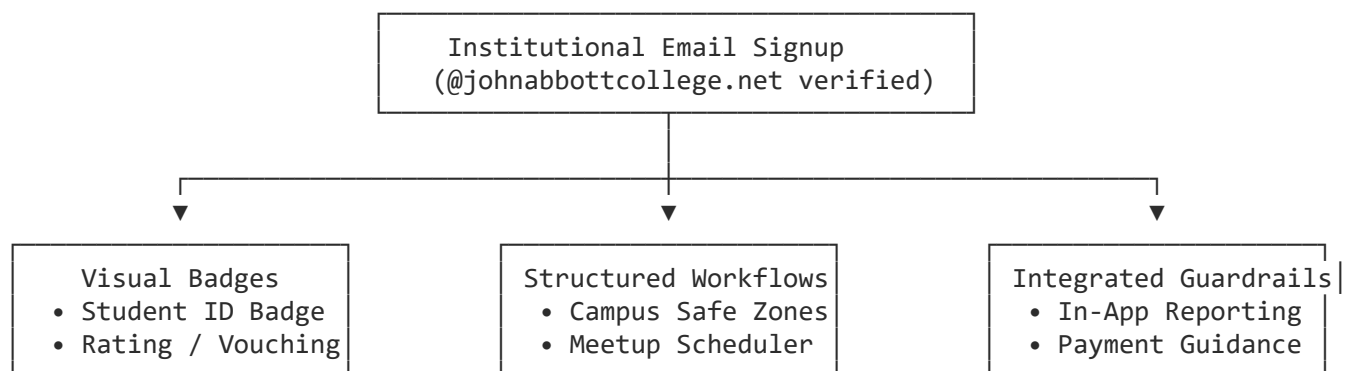
What You May Have Missed

- **Facebook Groups (The Real Competitor):** The primary alternative isn't just standard FB Marketplace; it's **unofficial student-run Facebook Groups** (e.g., *John Abbott College Used Books* or JAC student chat channels). These groups already have audience liquidity. Your app must be significantly easier to use than posting a photo to a group feed.
- **The "Cold Start" Problem (Network Effects):** Marketplaces suffer from a chicken-and-egg dilemma. Sellers won't post if there are no buyers, and buyers won't browse if there are no listings. Facebook succeeds because users are already logged into the app for other reasons. Your app must give students a compelling reason to open it daily.
- **Seasonality Friction:** Demand spikes heavily during the first 2 weeks and last 2 weeks of a semester (August/September and January). Outside these windows, transaction volume drops sharply. Expanding beyond textbooks to general items (electronics, dorm gear, clothing) is critical to keeping the app active mid-semester.

2. User Protection & Safety Enhancements

Using @johnabbottcollege.net email verification is an effective first boundary, but it isn't bulletproof (e.g., compromised student accounts, bad behavior from verified students).

To build a secure trading ecosystem without adding heavy operational overhead:



A. Identity & Reputation Controls

- **Peer Vouching / Simple Ratings:** After a completed trade, allow both users to leave a quick 1-to-5 star rating or a badge (e.g., "*Punctual*", "*Item as described*").
- **Profile Transparency:** Display a user's program/major or graduation year alongside a "*Verified Student*" badge to humanize interactions.

B. Architectural Meetup Guardrails

Instead of passive text warnings, **embed safe habits into the application UX**:

- **Preset "Campus Safe Zones"**: When two users agree to meet in chat, present a dropdown of recommended, high-visibility JAC locations:
 - *Herzberg Cafeteria*
 - *Stewart Hall Library Entrance*
 - *Casgrain Building Atrium*
- **Time-Bound Meetup Confirmations**: Allow buyers to tap a *"Schedule Meetup"* button in the chat specifying time and location. This establishes clear expectations and reduces ghosting.

C. In-App Warning Banners & Reporting

- **Contextual Banners**: Inside the chat view, display subtle, persistent security cues:
 - 🔒 **Safety Tip**: Meet only in public campus areas. Never send Interac e-Transfers *before* inspecting the item in person.
- **One-Tap Report & Block**: Give users a clear mechanism to report fraudulent listings, harassment, or non-responsive users. Flagged accounts can be quickly suspended by an admin.

Sources

1. [My JAC Portal Reference Guide - John Abbott College](#)

User prompt: oh yeah, we didn't think of facebook groups, that is a good competitor to keep in mind. As for getting the actual users, that would likely be a separate marketing problem, while we do agree it could be an issue, as getting users would be a hard step, so yeah thats good to keep in mind. We think it is still viable though if done right. As for the verification, the rating feature is a good idea, it will be kept in mind. Additionally, the idea of the recommended meet up locations from a drop down is really good, we like that idea a lot and think itll be a good implementation. The names being attached to the students as well should help stop them from scamming, although the possibility of fake/compromised accounts is good to keep in mind, which is why we have the other features to help prevent it. Lets keep all this in mind and go back to the users, what are some more of what their needs may be? such as pain points, etc?

Response: 1. Granular Academic Pain Points (Course-Specific Needs)

General platforms fail to capture the specific friction points of CEGEP life at John Abbott.

- **Editions & Lab Manual Confusion**: Textbook publishers frequently update editions (e.g., 6th vs 7th edition), or classes require specific course packs printed locally.
 - *The Pain Point*: Buyers end up buying the wrong edition from standard Facebook posts and realize too late in class.
 - *The Need*: Listings should explicitly require **Edition Number**, **ISBN**, and whether **online access codes** are included or already used.
- **Program-Specific Equipment**: Beyond textbooks, technical programs at JAC (e.g., Nursing, Paramedic, Dental, Engineering Technologies, Science) require physical gear like specific scrubs, lab coats, safety goggles, or specialized calculators (e.g., *TI-84* vs *Casio*).

- *The Pain Point:* These items are expensive new at the campus store and hard to locate on general marketplaces.
- *The Need:* Filter categories specific to JAC programs (e.g., *Science & Nursing Gear, Art & Design Supplies, Stationery/Calculators*).
- **Schedule Alignment & Class Deadlines:** Students often need an item *today* before a lab or exam.
 - *The Pain Point:* Waiting days for a response on Facebook Marketplace means missing a class deadline.
 - *The Need:* Real-time messaging or an indicator showing when a student is currently on campus (e.g., *"On Campus Today until 4 PM"* status tag).

2. Transaction & Social Friction (Behavioral Needs)

- **Ghosting & Flakiness:** CEGEP schedules are chaotic with gaps between classes, leading to missed handoffs.
 - *The Pain Point:* Buyers or sellers agree to meet at the Herzberg Cafeteria or Stewart Hall, but one party forgets or shows up late.
 - *The Need:* A simple in-chat **"Confirm Meetup"** trigger that sends a reminder notification 15 minutes before the scheduled time.
- **Negotiation & Cash Friction:** Students often dislike awkward face-to-face bargaining or not having exact change.
 - *The Pain Point:* Bargaining at the moment of exchange or dealing with exact change in cash.
 - *The Need:* Price tags should be final upon chat agreement, and payment method (Interac e-Transfer vs Cash) should be pre-agreed within the offer system.
- **Post-Semester Rush vs. Mid-Semester Slump:**
 - *The Pain Point:* Selling intent peaks during exam week and the first two weeks of classes, but drops to zero mid-semester.
 - *The Need:* An easy **"Bulk Upload"** feature for sellers offloading 4–5 textbooks at once at the end of term, plus non-book categories (dorm gear, clothing, electronics) to maintain app engagement mid-semester.

3. Campus-Specific Context for John Abbott

To make the app feel natively tailored to JAC, leverage the physical layout and daily student routines:

Feature Dimension	Generic Marketplace	JAC-Tailored App Solution
Location Tagging	City-wide / Radius in km	Specific JAC Buildings: Herzberg (H) , Stewart Hall (SH) , Casgrain (C) , Anne-Marie Edward (AME)
Search Filter	Title / Keyword search	Filter by JAC Department / Course Code (e.g., 201-NYA, 603-101)
Sellers / Identity	Anonymous or full public profile	Verified Student with Program/Year Badge (e.g., <i>Science, Year 2</i>)

Feature Dimension	Generic Marketplace	JAC-Tailored App Solution
Item Requests	Hidden or non-existent	" Wanted Board " where students request hard-to-find lab equipment or specific books

User prompt: Can you give me a summary of the key topics we have brainstormed so far

Response: Here is a concise executive summary of everything we have defined and brainstormed for the **John Abbott College (JAC) Student Marketplace**:

1. Product Concept & Positioning

- **The Concept:** A closed-loop, hyper-local marketplace app built exclusively for JAC students to buy, sell, and request course materials, equipment, and campus essentials.
- **Core Value Proposition:** Modern, safe, instant, and frictionless on-campus trading—bypassing shipping delays, fees, and off-campus meetups.
- **Key Differentiator:** Replacing scattered, broad platforms (Facebook Marketplace) and clunky, legacy systems (Omnivox secondhand book board, MIO) with a unified, modern solution tailored to JAC course structures.

2. Identified User Needs & Pain Points

- **Academic Precision:**
 - Avoid buying incorrect textbook editions, missing online access codes, or wrong lab pack printouts.
 - Easy discovery of program-specific physical gear (scrubs for Nursing, lab coats, goggles, specific TI-84/Casio calculators).
- **Speed & Timing:**
 - Urgent "same-day" needs (e.g., needing lab gear before a 2 PM class) solved via real-time messaging and an **On-Campus Status Tag** ("On campus until 4 PM").
 - High-volume seasonal peaks (start/end of term) requiring **Bulk Listing** features, balanced by non-book items (electronics, clothing, dorm gear) to prevent mid-term inactivity.
- **Frictionless Handoffs:**
 - Eliminating ghosting/flakiness through structured **In-Chat Meetup Confirmations**.
 - Clearing up bargaining/payment confusion before meeting up (pre-agreed Cash vs. Interac e-Transfer).

3. Trust, Safety & Verification Architecture

- **Access Control:** Institutional email gating via @johnabbottcollege.net accounts to block non-students.
- **Reputation Systems:**
 - Simple 1–5 star buyer/seller ratings and peer badges ("Punctual", "Item as described").
 - Profile context (showing verified student status, program/major, and graduation year).

- **Built-In Campus Safe Zones:**

- In-chat drop-down selector to lock in high-visibility, public JAC meetup spots:

- **Herzberg (H)** Cafeteria / Agora
- **Stewart Hall (SH)** Library / Entrance
- **Casgrain (C)** Sports Centre / Atrium
- **Anne-Marie Edward (AME)** Building

- **Security Guardrails:** Safety reminder banners inside chat (warning against sending e-Transfers before inspecting items in person) and a 1-tap Report & Block mechanism.

4. Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Core Scope

1. **Authentication:** Closed @johnabbottcollege.net registration.
2. **Search & Browse:** Category filters + **JAC Course Code tagging** (e.g., 201-NYA, 603-101).
3. **The "Wanted / Request" Board:** A tab where students post items they need so sellers can reach out directly.
4. **In-App Messaging:** 1-on-1 real-time chat featuring the **Campus Meetup Scheduler**.
5. **Item Lifecycle:** Status tags (Available, Pending, Sold).

Sources

1. [John Abbott College - Wikipedia](#)
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User prompt: what is a quick overlook of our user needs, not just pain points

Response: Here is a concise overview of your users' primary needs across the entire journey—from browsing to handoff:

1. Discovery & Match Accuracy Needs

- **Course Code Alignment:** Users need to search directly by official JAC course codes (e.g., 201-NYA-05) or program categories (e.g., Nursing, Science, Police Tech) to guarantee the item is exact for their syllabus.
- **Item Condition Transparency:** Buyers need immediate clarity on book edition numbers, lab coat sizes, calculator models, and whether required online access codes are already used or included.
- **Proactive Sourcing ("Wanted" Needs):** Requesters need a dedicated space to post requests for hard-to-find or sold-out items (e.g., specific lab manuals or program gear) so sellers can come to them.

2. Convenience & Speed Needs

- **Same-Day / Immediate Access:** Students often need gear or textbooks *today* before a lab or class starts. They need real-time messaging and an indicator showing when a seller is physically on campus.
- **Low-Effort Listing Process:** Sellers want to list an item in under a minute directly from their phones (quick photo upload, auto-filled course tags, and bulk-listing for multi-textbook offloading at the end of a semester).

- **Zero-Cost Handoffs:** Both parties need to trade locally on campus to avoid shipping fees, packaging hassle, or travelling far off-campus.

3. Trust & Social Friction Needs

- **Peer Safety & Identity Assurance:** Users need to know they are interacting with a real, verified John Abbott student, backed by basic profile context (program, year) and peer ratings.
 - **Predictable Handoffs:** Students need structured meetup tools—preset campus locations (Herzberg, Stewart Hall, Casgrain) and clear time confirmations—to eliminate ghosting, lateness, and endless back-and-forth messaging.
 - **Awkwardness-Free Transactions:** Buyers and sellers need pre-agreed prices and payment terms (Cash vs. Interac e-Transfer) established before meeting in person to avoid last-minute haggling.
-